

Project Brief

Content Sunsetting Programme Tracker · Programme documentation · Ndivhuwo
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Sableridge Exchange (SRX) · Website Content Sunsetting and Migration Readiness Prepared by the Digital Team ·
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About this document. This is the governing brief for the Content Sunsetting Programme Tracker: the process design, the decision vocabulary, the roles and the tracking model. All of that is real and is the author's own work. **Sableridge Exchange is a fictitious organisation** and every figure, name and URL in the accompanying files is synthetic. Nothing here describes any real organisation's website, staff or decisions.

1. Purpose

This brief states what the sunsetting programme achieves, how the work is carried out, what each business division is asked to do, and how progress is tracked. It is the programme's reference record.

It is written for people who did not design the programme: divisional representatives being asked to make decisions, and anyone who later has to account for why a page was retired.

2. Background

A corporate website of any size grows one page at a time, over years, and faster than anyone retires anything. Pages are added for a campaign, a product launch, a regulatory notice or a single event. They are rarely removed afterwards, because removing one requires somebody to be confident it is no longer needed. Nothing forces that question to be asked, so it is not asked.

A move to a new content management system is when the question finally has to be answered. Migration carries content forward page by page, so every page becomes a decision.

The obstacle at that point is not technical. The business context for a page does not sit with the team that runs the website. The digital team can see every URL, its traffic and its position in the site structure, and none of the things that determine whether a page still matters: whether a service behind it is live, whether a client group relies on it, whether a commitment made in it still stands. That knowledge sits with the division that asked for the page.

The programme is built around obtaining and recording that context rather than inferring it.

3. Problem statement

The binding constraint is ownership, not volume.

On an estate of any age, a given page usually cannot be traced to a person who will answer for it. The team that requested it has reorganised, the individual who owned it has moved on, or it was never assigned to anyone. That gap blocks everything downstream.

- **No one can authorise a removal.** Without an accountable owner there is no one to ask and no one to sign off, so the safe default is to keep the page, which is the behaviour that produces the accumulation in the first place.

- **A decision leaves no defensible record.** If a page is removed and someone asks six months later why, "it looked out of date" is not an answer. A decision needs a named person, a stated reason and a date attached to it.
- **Progress cannot be measured.** Without a per-page record there is no way to say how much has been reviewed, how much is agreed and how much has not been looked at, so the work cannot be planned or resourced.
- **Traffic alone will not decide it.** Page views are evidence, not a decision rule. A page with almost no traffic may carry a standing regulatory commitment. Volume ranks candidates; it does not settle them.
- **Migration inherits every unresolved page.** Anything not decided before the move is decided by default, in favour of carrying it across.

The programme resolves all five by making **every URL carry a named custodian, a decision, a reason and a date**, in one model.

4. Objectives

1. Establish a custodian, accountable by name, for every URL.
2. Record exactly one decision per URL from a controlled vocabulary, with a reason and the date it was taken.
3. Route each page to its correct outcome, distinguishing content being retired from content being relocated. These have opposite consequences and are routinely conflated.
4. Produce an audit trail that can account for any individual page decision after the fact.
5. Give the migration a verified input set, and leave a standing ownership register that outlives it.

5. Scope

Every URL on the main website, grouped by the business division responsible for it.

In scope: identifying the responsible division and custodian; obtaining a decision for each URL; recording the decision, reason and date; unpublishing what is confirmed as no longer required; preparing the verified set for migration.

Out of scope: the migration itself, content rewriting, site redesign, and any change to the pages carried forward. The programme decides what moves. It does not move it.

Not every URL is a web page. A content management system exposes stored files, such as documents and images, as URLs too, and on a mature estate those outnumber public pages heavily. They are in scope, because they need decisions like anything else, but they sit in a separate section of the model and are never mixed into a page count.

6. Key definitions

Term	Meaning
Sunsetting	The controlled retirement of a page: taking it out of service, with a recorded decision, reason and date. Used in preference to "deleting" because several of the available outcomes are not deletions.
Custodian	The named person accountable for a page. Not its author and not its approver, but the person who answers for whether it should still exist.
Active page	A page that remains relevant to current users, supports a live service, or is otherwise still required.
Legacy page	A page no longer relevant to a current audience or service, and a candidate for retirement. A page-level classification, applied case by case and confirmed with the division.
Sitemap	The machine-readable index a site publishes to tell search engines and analytics tools which pages exist. A page absent from it is reachable if the address is known, but is largely invisible and has no traffic evidence.

Term	Meaning
Media Library	Handles by which stored files are reachable in the content management system. They are URLs but not web pages, and they are counted separately throughout.
Controlled vocabulary	A fixed list of permitted values for a field, enforced at entry. Used wherever a field's set of valid answers is closed by design.

7. Approach

Each division receives the list of URLs assigned to it and the assessment criteria below, and reaches a decision on each. A verification discussion is then held with the division to confirm those decisions page by page.

The form is the preparation, not the mechanism. A returned form answers what a division wants. A discussion establishes whether the division is the right party to be answering, surfaces pages that two divisions both claim or neither claims, and produces agreement rather than a submission.

7.1 Assessment criteria

1. **Consolidation potential:** whether the content can be combined with one or more other pages, so the same information is served from fewer places.
2. **Client base and target audience:** who the content is for, and whether an identifiable group of users actively relies on it.
3. **Service and use-case verification:** whether the page forms part of a live service, or otherwise serves a current, verifiable use case.

The three are ordered from cheapest to hardest to answer. A division that cannot answer the third for a page has, in effect, already answered it.

7.2 Decision for each page

Decision	Meaning
Keep	The page is active and relevant; it is retained and carried forward.
Consolidate	The content should be merged into another page, which the division identifies.
Sunset	The page is no longer required and should be unpublished.

The form offers three values; the tracker records ten. A division is being asked what it wants for its content, not to select a programme procedure. Translating a coarse divisional answer into a precise procedure is a digital-team judgment, and it is recorded as an explicit step so that judgment stays visible in the audit trail.

The decision is captured in one validated column rather than three tick-boxes, so exactly one answer is possible and a blank unambiguously means unanswered. The consolidation target is free text, because a respondent has to be able to nominate any page on the estate.

8. Roles and responsibilities

Party	Responsibility
Digital Team	Owns the programme. Compiles and groups the URL list; issues page lists and criteria; convenes the verification discussions; translates divisional decisions into programme procedures; records outcomes; maintains the tracker; carries out the unpublishing.
Business divisions	Review the pages assigned to them; apply the assessment criteria; return a decision and supporting context for each page; attend the verification discussion; confirm the agreed outcomes.
Page custodians	Provide the business context for specific pages, and stand as the named accountable party for the content they hold.

Accountability is recorded by name, not by team. A decision attributed to a division cannot be followed up; a decision attributed to a person can. Where no individual can be identified, that fact is itself recorded rather than left blank, because content no one owns is exactly the content that otherwise gets missed.

9. Progress tracking dashboard

A two-page dashboard reads the programme's record sets and serves as its central console, so that the state of the work is a matter of record rather than of recollection.

Page 1, Sunsetting Tracker. Headline measures for total pages, URLs discussed, procedures confirmed, the confirmed percentage and the count of accountable parties; the distribution of decisions across the estate; breakdowns by division and by custodian; a progress-stage view; and a detail table. Sliceable by website section, decision and division.

Page 2, Custodianship Analysis. Headline measures for total pages, accountable parties, custodians confirmed and the confirmed percentage; the confirmed and unconfirmed split; and breakdowns by custodian, division and website section.

URLs discussed and **procedures confirmed** are deliberately kept as separate measures. A page can be discussed and then deferred to a further session, so it is discussed but not confirmed. The gap between them is the programme's deferred backlog, and a single progress measure would hide it.

10. Process flow

Step	Stage	Description
1	Preparation	Every URL is compiled, classified by website section and grouped by the division responsible; the tracker is populated.
2	Engagement	Each division receives its page list, the assessment criteria and an invitation to a verification discussion.
3	Internal review	The division reviews its pages before the discussion and records a decision for each.
4	Verification discussion	The Digital Team and the division confirm, page by page, which pages are Keep, Consolidate or Sunset.
5	Recording	Divisional decisions are translated into programme procedures and written to the tracker with a reason and the discussion date.
6	Sunsetting	Confirmed pages are unpublished, or routed to their agreed destination.

Step	Stage	Description
7	Migration readiness	The verified set is handed to the migration as a decided, evidenced input.

Step 5 is a translation step, not a transcription step, and is listed separately so that the judgment it involves stays visible.

A page nobody owns cannot be marked for retirement. This is enforced in the data, not left to discipline: a URL whose custodian is still unconfirmed cannot carry a confirmed decision.

11. Indicative timeline

Each division receives its page list and meeting invitation approximately **two weeks** before its scheduled verification discussion. Specific dates are confirmed with each division in its invitation.

Two weeks is calibrated against what is actually being asked. A division cannot answer the assessment criteria from memory. It has to check which services are live and consult the people who requested the content. With less time, the discussion becomes the division's first look at its list, which turns a confirmation meeting into a review meeting and doubles the number of sessions. Divisions are engaged in waves rather than all at once, so the discussions stay small enough to go page by page.

12. Expected outcomes

1. Every URL carries a named custodian, a decision, a reason and a date, held in one model.
2. Active pages and pages no longer required are distinguished explicitly, and agreed with the division that owns them rather than determined for it.
3. Any individual page decision can be accounted for after the fact.
4. Content is routed to its correct destination, with retirement and relocation recorded distinctly.
5. The migration receives a decided, verified input set.
6. The ownership register persists after the migration, so the same question does not have to be answered from scratch again.

Outcome 6 is the one that determines whether this was worth doing. A migration is a single event; the accumulation of unowned content is continuous. The lasting deliverable is not the reduced page set. It is the register and the habit of recording ownership.